

Sony's PS3 update could affect supercomputer users



Sony Playstation

If you're one of the many scientists and researchers using a [PlayStation 3](#) as a cheap alternative to a supercomputer, you'll want to steer clear of Sony's latest firmware update.

[Sony](#) will offer a software upgrade on 1 April that will disable the "Install Other OS" feature that was available on PS3 systems prior to the slimmer models. The feature allowed users to run Linux on the console. Now, Sony says "security concerns" have forced it to remove the functionality.

Users who get the latest OS version will lose access to their older data after the update, says a Sony spokesperson.

The PlayStation 3 has emerged as a favourite among researchers looking to create [homebrew supercomputers on the cheap](#). When clustered, the PS3's Cell processor -- developed by Sony, IBM and Toshiba -- can rival the power of a supercomputer, say some researchers.

University of Massachusetts Dartmouth Physics Professor Gaurav Khanna, for instance,

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created a [step-by-step guide to building a supercomputer using the PS3](#) that could potentially reduce the cost of general computing research.

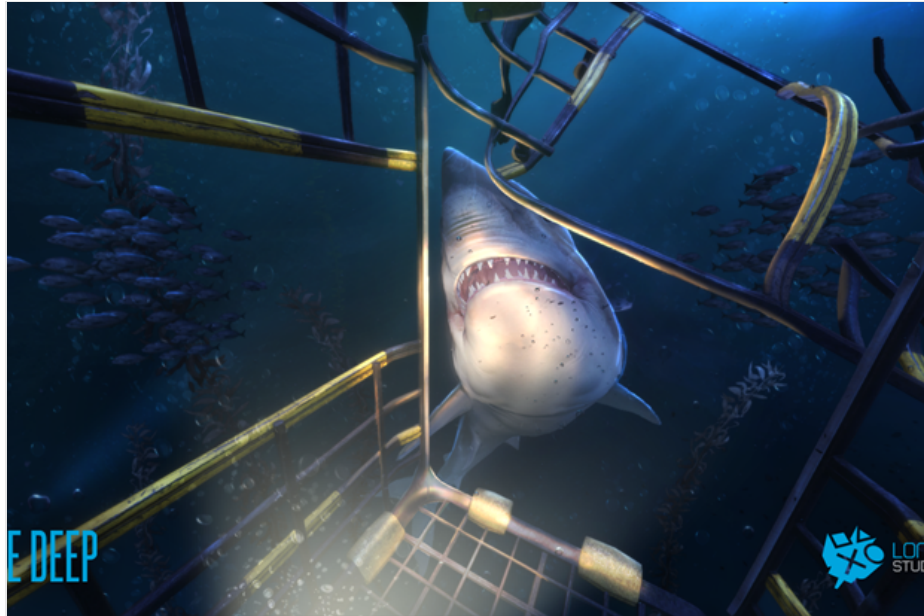
Stanford has a [Folding@home initiative](#) where PS3 users can sign up to use their machine as part of a distributed computing project that simulates protein folding.

PS3 users not choosing to upgrade to the latest version will pay a price. They will lose the ability to sign into the online PlayStation Network, chat or play Blu-ray discs that require the latest version of the operating system.

But if you are trying to model the effect of gravitational waves or molecular dynamics, you probably won't miss those features much, anyway.

Edited by George Barrow

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